Introduction

Once, on a Saturday afternoon, during the monsoon months of 1961, we were having our ritual family lunch at my grandparents' home in Carmichael House, on Carmichael Road, in what was then Bombay.[1] Suddenly, the doorbell rang. Hearing a minor commotion, I ran from the dining room to the hall, where I saw several *hamaals*, or bearers, unloading bundles of linen and carpets. I overheard my grandmother telling my aunt that my grandfather[2] had bought an entire store's unused stock of specially monogrammed 'HM'[3] linen. He had also bought three large, customised Kashmiri 'Maharaja' Carpets; they were exquisite. These carpets, along with some pieces of royal furniture and artefacts belonging to the late Maharaja Hari Singh of Jammu and Kashmir, were sold in a public auction following the Maharaja's death in April 1961. He had passed away in Bombay while in exile.

My grandfather was born in Muzaffarabad, which was then a part of the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir.[4] My great-grandfather, Faqir Chand Malhotra, was a barrister; a friend and advisor to the then monarch, Maharaja Pratap Singh. My grandfather and Maharaja Hari Singh were acquaintances who would meet every Sunday afternoon at Bombay's Royal Western India Turf Club; they had the two best adjoining boxes at the Turf Club and shared a common passion for fillies.

Two summers later, in May 1963, my grandparents drove up our Cadillac Eldorado from Delhi to Gulmarg, with our whole family on board. We rented a hut[5] in Gulmarg and I remember going for daily horse rides, accompanied by the hostlers who would provide horses to my grandfather every time he drove down to Gulmarg from Lahore to spend his summers in the pre-Partition years. I remember my grandfather telling me about the Partition; how we lost our ancestral home in Muzaffarabad and, with it, our